between agnosticism and militant atheism. “Faith unites us, knowledge gives us freedom. We shall therefore prevent any theocratic tendencies from coming to the fore on the part of our priesthood. We shall keep our priests within the confines of their temples,” Herzl wrote in *Der Judenstaat*, his 1896 pamphlet on the planned Jewish state.

In 1912, hundreds of rabbis met in the German town of Kattowitz (now Katowice, in modern-day Poland) to found Agudat Israel (“Union of Israel”), an umbrella movement for anti-Zionist Jews. It was a powerful force until World War II, when much of European Jewry was wiped out. By 1948, the remaining leaders of the Agudah had moderated their anti-Zionism, opting instead for a sort of non-Zionism, since the state of Israel might be useful as a shelter for the remnants of their community.

Their opposition was still a problem for David Ben-Gurion and the other early leaders of Israel. It looked bad, of course: Jewish divisions over the Jewish state would undermine Israel’s legitimacy. But there was also a more pragmatic consideration, one that remains valid today. He thought the ultra-Orthodox could make good coalition partners. They didn’t have a position on the fierce debates over how to organize the new state and its economy. By appeasing them, Ben-Gurion could help to secure a majority in the first Knesset. “If he’d fought on all fronts simultaneously and with the same passion—socialism versus communism, secularism versus religion, a free-market economy versus a centrally directed economy—he’d have united all of them against him and remained in the minority,” Shimon Peres recalled.

A year before Israel declared independence, Ben-Gurion, then the chairman of the Jewish Agency, sent a letter to Agudat Israel. He outlined an arrangement now referred to as the “status quo” (a phrase that gets a lot of use in Israel). The letter made four pledges on key questions of religion and state. Shabbat would be the official day of rest for Jews. The state would offer kosher food in official dining facilities. A single authority would oversee personal-status issues like marriage, which meant, in practice, that the Orthodox would control such matters for Jews (non-Jews have their own parallel structures). And religious communities would have the right to manage their own schools, albeit with certain minimum standards for language, science, and other secular fields. The following year, he agreed to the Council of Yeshivot’s demand that “Torah scholars” be excluded from the army draft.